

THE DAILY BRIEF

SEPTEMBER 28, 2026

AI & TECH

Major moves across labs, policy, and infrastructure financing

Anthropic's Dario Amodei has dinner with Trump — first one-on-one. Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei sat down with President Trump at the White House Sunday night, the first face-to-face between the two men after months of public friction. The meeting came hours after Amodei was parodied on Saturday Night Live, and a week after he published a plan to "slow the frontier." Trump has called the AI safety backlash a "Democratic hoax" and wants to rebrand the technology as "super intelligence." The Pentagon earlier this year designated Anthropic a supply-chain risk over its refusal to remove guardrails from Claude — Anthropic won its first court fight against that label in August. (TechCrunch)

The Pentagon, separately, won a ruling allowing it to keep blacklisting Anthropic over the company's refusal to enable certain Claude features — a second front that has been quietly running alongside the dinner conversation. (Ars Technica)

AI's \$575 billion debt problem just got more expensive. Treasury yields pushed to their highest since 2007 this week, and the financing math for the AI buildout is changing fast. SoftBank raised \$11.1 billion in junk bonds last week at yields as high as 9.75% on the seven-year tranche — a record for the conglomerate — to keep funding its OpenAI commitments. Global AI-related debt issuance has already crossed \$575 billion in 2026, per Goldman Sachs credit strategists. The market is starting to thin out: "Instead of a roster of 50 neoclouds, there's probably 20 that the market's truly interested in," Bank of America credit strategist Michael Thompson said. CoreWeave, which has warned in SEC filings that every 100 basis points of rate increase adds roughly \$30 million to its interest expense, is up about 8% on the week. Oracle, which has leaned on debt for its AI expansion, is down 7% on the week and roughly 30% year-to-date. (CNBC, Japan Times)

Google is testing Flipkart shopping inside Gemini and AI Mode for a small slice of Indian users, with a broader rollout planned later in October. The move turns Walmart-owned Flipkart into a real product surface for Google's AI shopping agents. (TechCrunch)

MARKETS & FINANCE

Premarket action, trade truce, and the AI infrastructure financing gap

Stocks are softer across the board in early trade. Futures fell overnight after Friday's strong close: Dow futures 51,886 (-0.53%), S&P; 500 futures 7,765 (-0.50%), Nasdaq 100 futures 30,602 (-0.93%). Friday's cash session closed green — Dow +0.93%, S&P; 500 +0.81%, Nasdaq +0.48% — so the early softness looks more like position-trimming than a directional move. The bigger question underneath is the same one hanging over AI: how does the equity story change if Treasury yields stay near two-decade highs? (Markets Insider, prior session via CNBC)

The U.S. and China just announced \$60 billion in mutual tariff cuts. Following last week's Trump–Xi summit in Washington, the two governments published product lists on Monday — 77 Chinese items from fireworks and tableware to Christmas decorations and toys on the U.S. side; 1,619 U.S. items on China's side, dominated by agricultural products including soybeans, pork, chicken feet, whiskey and roasted peanuts. Each side cuts \$30 billion. Last year's tariffs were north of 40% (U.S.) and 30% (China) on each other's goods. The truce was extended to January, but the exact timing of the cuts and how far duties will fall hasn't been published yet. For context, the U.S. goods trade deficit with China was more than \$202 billion last year. (CNBC)

Strategy bought 1,665 more bitcoins for \$143 million, bringing its total to 847,666 BTC. The company disclosed the purchase in a Sept. 28 8-K filing. Average price paid: \$85,681 per coin. Total spent across all buys: \$63.95 billion, at an average cost basis of \$75,437 including fees. The week's playbook was familiar: sell MSTR stock for cash, buy BTC, repurchase STRC preferred. Specifically, Strategy sold 1.47 million shares of common stock for \$246.2 million in net proceeds; \$142.7 million went to bitcoin, \$103.5 million to STRC buybacks. The company is also holding \$6.02 billion in USD assets with a 3.8-year duration, and reports STRC's BTC Credit spread at 49 basis points. (Cointelegraph, The Block)

Bitget confirms a \$351.6 million hack it blames on North Korea, and starts repaying customers. Bitget said the breach was detected at 18:31 UTC on Sept. 24 — an attacker compromised a backend system in the exchange's wallet infrastructure, used it to spoof transaction data, and triggered Bitget's own authorization process to move funds out across seven blockchains. Private keys were not compromised, the exchange said; cold wallets were untouched. Stolen assets: ETH, XRP, BNB, AVAX, USDT and USDC, sent across Ethereum, XRP Ledger, Arbitrum, Avalanche, Optimism, BSC and Base. Circle and Tether have frozen about \$339,100 in stablecoins. Phased withdrawals resumed Monday. By total dollar value, this is now the largest crypto heist of 2026 — bigger than KelpDAO's \$292 million and Drift's \$285 million thefts. (The Hacker News, Fortune, The Block)

A federal appeals court just told Kalshi it can be regulated like a sportsbook — again. On Friday, the 6th U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals ruled unanimously that Ohio and Tennessee can enforce their gambling laws against Kalshi's sports event contracts. Writing for the panel, Judge Julia Smith Gibbons held that Kalshi's sports products don't qualify as "swaps" under Dodd-Frank, so the CFTC doesn't have exclusive jurisdiction over them — and that even if they did, the Commodity Exchange Act wouldn't preempt state gambling law. This is Kalshi's second appellate loss in roughly a month: the 9th Circuit ruled the same way in the Nevada case in August. The 3rd Circuit went the other way in New Jersey in April, and that case is now teed up at the Supreme Court after New Jersey asked the justices to take it on Sept. 2. A bipartisan coalition of 44 states is pressing enforcement actions; Kalshi faces more than a dozen state lawsuits plus three tribal ones. (CNBC, The Block)

BRIEFLY

◀ **Bitcoin ETF inflows:** Spot BTC ETFs added \$2.4 billion in the week ended Sept. 26, their largest weekly inflow since October. (The Block)

◀ **Vitalik maps Ethereum to 2030:** Vitalik Buterin published a new framing for Ethereum's next five years, arguing the network is now "really not just a blockchain anymore." (The Block)

◀ **Newsom vs. memecoins:** California Governor Gavin Newsom signed a bill banning public officials from launching memecoins and explicitly named the practice in the same breath as the Trump family's crypto ventures. (The Block)

< **The 10-year yield is back in focus** at its highest level in nearly two decades — the structural backdrop behind everything in the AI debt story. (CNBC)

< **Anthropic on SNL:** Dario Amodei got the Saturday Night Live treatment the night before his White House dinner — a coincidence the cultural and policy timelines lined up to produce. (TechCrunch)

THE TAKEAWAY

Three threads ran through this morning's tape and they all connect. The U.S.–China tariff announcement is the cleanest macro event: \$60 billion in targeted relief, mostly aimed at keeping holiday-season retail prices down, and it's the first concrete deliverable from last week's Trump–Xi summit. The *Kalshi* ruling is the legal one: prediction platforms are now 1-2 in federal appellate courts, with a Supreme Court fight almost certainly next. And the AI financing story is the one with the longest shadow — SoftBank's \$11.1 billion junk-bond sale at 9.75% is the most visible data point yet that the cost of building the AI economy is being repriced upward at exactly the moment the capital plan needs to keep flowing. Strategy's relentless bitcoin accumulation is the cleanest counter-example: a treasury strategy whose only dependency is equity issuance, not credit markets, and that is now sitting on 847,666 BTC bought at an average of \$75,437 — underwater by about \$1,800 per coin at today's price.

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